

3.2 Grammar

GCSE students will be expected to develop and use their knowledge of grammar throughout their course.

The grammar requirements for GCSE are set out in two tiers: Foundation and Higher. Students are required to use their knowledge of grammar from the specified lists, appropriate to the relevant tier of entry. Students entering Higher tier assessments will be required to apply all grammar listed for Foundation tier in addition to the grammar listed for Higher tier.

Students will be expected to use the prescribed grammar across a range of contexts and assessment tasks.

The lists describe grammatical features of the most widely used standard varieties.

The lists are written from the point of view of English-speaking students of the language, and so include some reference to certain cross-linguistically complex relations with English.

Students are required to demonstrate both receptive and productive knowledge of the grammar from the list (although the derivational morphology laid out in the grammar annex can only be included for Paper 3 Reading).

'Grammar' is defined as including the morphology (inflectional and derivational) and syntax (rules of word order, relations between words and obligatory use of specific features). The vocabulary lists contain the lexicon that is needed to apply the grammar.

Some grammatical features can be perceived as 'grammar' or 'lexicon' – these items are listed in the vocabulary list, as stipulated in the DfE Subject Content. The vocabulary list also specifies highly irregular forms within a grammatical subsystem (ie, subparts of paradigms where only some forms are irregular), as laid out in the Grammar requirements. This is because forms, such as irregular stems, are likely to be learnt and retrieved as individual items rather than as part of a broader grammatical system. Listing them in the vocabulary list, therefore, reflects the pedagogical attention required for these highly irregular forms.

Items given in brackets in the grammar list which are prefaced with 'eg' are illustrative, ie serve only to clarify the description of the grammar features, and such items are not included in the vocabulary list. In contrast, items that are not prefaced by 'eg' are comprehensive, providing all the examples of the grammar that are included in the DfE Subject Content, and all such items are contained in the vocabulary list.

Note that the English equivalents of some of the grammar are provided. This is relevant when testing students' ability to work from English to Spanish (eg, in translation tasks).